Meeting 1: Kickoff and Brainstorm

Bachelor Project 2025–2026
Digital Governance, Platform Labour, and Power in the Digital Economy

Dr. Shreyas Meher
Department of Public Administration and Sociology
Erasmus University Rotterdam

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Today's Agenda

1. Welcome and introductions
2. Course logistics: timeline, structure, grading, deadlines
3. How this thesis circle runs: supervisor and peer feedback
4. Academic integrity and AI tools
5. General feedback on Assignment 1
6. From topic to a testable research question
7. Our theme: angles and first-round brainstorm
8. Next steps and peer-feedback pairings

Part 1

Welcome and course logistics

Welcome

- The thesis is an **independent research** project on a topic of your choice within our theme
- Over 9 to 10 weeks you design, execute, and write up the project
- My role is to guide; the research is yours

Course Timeline at a Glance

Week	Date	Focus
1	Apr 23	Kickoff and brainstorm
2	Apr 30	Introduction (C1) and theory / lit review (C2)
3	May 7	Revisions of C1 and C2
4	May 13	Methodology (C3) + privacy checklist + consent
5	May 21	General progress
6	May 28	Findings and analysis (C4)
7	Jun 4	Revised findings, draft conclusions (C5)
8	Jun 11	Bachelor Project Conference (EUC)
9	Jun 18	Individual consultations (1-on-1)
	Jun 25	**Final submission**

Thesis Structure and Word Counts

Component	Words
Abstract	200
C1.1 Introduction and topic orientation	250–400
C1.2 Problem formulation and research question	250–400
C2 Theoretical framework	2000–2500
C3 Research design and methodological justification	500–1000
C4 Empirical findings and analysis	3500–4000
C5.1 Conclusions	500–800
C5.2 Recommendations	300
Bibliography	300

Important

Hard cap: 10,000 words, all-inclusive. You can move wordcount between components, but not beyond the cap.

Grading Criteria

80% Content

- Clarity of the problem formulation
- Critical incorporation of the literature (min. 5 peer-reviewed articles)
- Conversion of theoretical insights into your own conceptual model
- Quality of operationalization and methodological justification
- Systematic application of the theoretical perspective in the analysis
- A line of reasoning that can be clearly followed
- Quality and depth of analysis in the conclusions

10% Formal requirements

10% Process requirements

Full rubric is in the Bachelor Project Course Manual on Canvas.

Key Deadlines

Thesis deadline → 25 June 2026 at 23:59

Thesis retake deadline → 13 August 2026 at 23:59

Part 2

How this thesis circle runs

How the thesis circle works

Weekly rhythm

- **Tuesday 10:59**: upload your chapter draft to Canvas
- **Thursday**: thesis circle meeting with my written feedback already in hand

Meeting format

- **This week (Meeting 1)**: all 8 of you together, plenary format
- **From Meeting 2 onwards**: you split into **two groups of 4**, each group gets a **70-minute** slot
- Within each group of 4, I will assign **cross-feedback pairs** for the weekly peer review

Attendance

- Attendance = (a) weekly submission on time, *and* (b) physical presence
- 2 missed sessions triggers a formal warning; more than 3 terminates supervision

Course website and slides

Session materials are posted on:

`https://shreyasmeher.github.io/bachelor-project`

- **Password**: `BachProject2026` (case sensitive)
- Slides unlock on Thursday afternoon, after each meeting
- Full schedule is on the site; locked sessions show the release date

Canvas remains the place for submissions, feedback, and announcements.

Groups of 4 and cross-feedback pairs

From Meeting 2 (30 April) onwards, the circle splits into two groups of 4. Each group gets an 80-minute slot. Within each group, two cross-feedback pairs exchange drafts each week.

Group A *12:00–13:20*
(text-as-data / cross-national)

- Kate Domnikoff *pair 1*
- Lea Gé9ciové1 *pair 1*
- Kseniya Sidorenko *pair 2*
- Daniel Ugarte *pair 2*

Group B *13:25–14:45*
(case / applied / mixed)

- Anand Dev Esponda *pair 1*
- Vince Kromberg *pair 1*
- Francis van Luyn *pair 2*
- Louiza Reysen *pair 2*

Pairings are stable across the term; if you would prefer a different pairing, let me know by Friday.

What you can expect from me

- **Written feedback on every weekly submission**, delivered via Canvas before the Thursday meeting
- **General feedback** in the meeting: common issues, what to push on, what to drop
- **Literature pointers**: authors and directions you may not have found
- **Methodological guidance**: operationalisation, design, what is feasible in 9 to 10 weeks
- **Availability** via email between meetings

I will not write your thesis or hand you a research question. I help you sharpen your own.

What I expect from you

- **Submit on time** every week, even when the draft feels rough
- **Come prepared**: read my feedback before the meeting and bring questions
- **Own your project**: this is your research, not mine, and the choices are yours to make and defend
- **Give constructive peer feedback**: specific, actionable, with a purpose
- **Start data work early**: by Week 5 you should have data in hand, not plans for data
- **Ask when stuck**: earlier is cheaper than later

Peer feedback: what "constructive" means

Not useful

- "This is unclear"
- "Good start, looks fine"
- "I would rewrite everything"
- Correcting typos while skipping the argument

Useful

- "In paragraph 2 I could not tell what your dependent variable is"
- "Your RQ is prescriptive; a testable version would be X"
- "The theory section jumps from Zuboff to DMA without a bridge"
- "If you only have 6 weeks, 10 interviews will be tight"

Academic Integrity and AI Tools

Important

All theses are scanned for **plagiarism and AI-generated content**. High AI proportions are referred to the Examination Board.

- Proper citation is not optional. When in doubt, **cite the source**
- AI tools can support brainstorming, outlining, editing. Do **not** copy or paste generated content
- AI-based translation often fails AI-content checks. Proofread carefully
- Be transparent: if you used AI, document how. You remain responsible for everything in the thesis

Part 3

General feedback on Assignment 1

Assignment 1: what went well

Across the eight submissions I saw ambitious and genuinely interesting topics: EU privacy regulation conflicts, media concentration and democracy, digital sovereignty, global digital supply chains, ASEAN digital geopolitics, e-government accessibility, digital repression in Russia, and the legalisation of digital censorship.

- Most of you already named concrete **data sources** (V-Dem, Freedom on the Net, OVD-Info, AidData, enforcement trackers). Good instinct.
- Several submissions made an honest **pivot** from an unworkable idea to a feasible one. That is exactly what this first stage is for.
- A few of you already drafted **hypotheses** or a clean **X-Y logic**. Keep going.

Assignment 1: common issues to work on

Four patterns I saw repeatedly:

1. **Research questions framed prescriptively or normatively**. "How can businesses overcome…" or "How should democracy respond…" generates advice, not evidence. Reframe as an explanatory question.
2. **Scope too broad for 9 to 10 weeks**. Several projects bundled two dependent variables, three regions, or an entire policy field. Pick one layer and defend it.
3. **Grey literature dominating**. Commission press pages, think-tank reports, and news articles are fine as context, but C2 requires at least **5 peer-reviewed international journal articles**. Start your search on sEURch, Web of Science, and Scopus this week.
4. **Operationalisation left vague**. Several of you have a clear concept of X but no plan for how to measure Y. Commit to specific indicators before 28/04.

Concrete, testable, empirical variables

A useful template for the research question:

*What is the influence of **X** on **Y** in context **Z**?*

- **X**: the **independent** variable or cause(s). Name it.
- **Y**: the **dependent** variable or outcome(s). Name it, and name the **indicator** you will use to measure it.
- **Z**: the **scope**: time period, country, sector, population.

If you cannot state X, Y, and Z in one sentence, you have a research area, not a research question.

Five questions to ask before your next submission

Before you submit your revised C1 and C2 on 28 April:

1. Can I state my **dependent variable** in one sentence, and name the exact **indicator** I will use?
2. Does my RQ **test or explain** something, rather than prescribe or describe it?
3. Do I have **five or more peer-reviewed articles** lined up, not just reports?
4. Is my **data accessible** within 2 to 3 weeks, and do I have a **Plan B**?
5. If a classmate read my one-pager, could they tell me **what I study, how, and why it matters**?

Individual feedback per student is on Canvas.

Part 4

From topic to a research question

Types of research questions

Aim	Example	Note
Exploration	"How do gig workers experience. . . ?"	Starting point
Description	"What features does X have?"	Not enough on its own
Explanation	**"Why has X happened? Under what conditions does A lead to B?"**	**What we push for**
Testing	**"Has A increased more in year t than t-1?"**	**What we push for**
Diagnosis	"What obstacles or stimuli for change?"	Specific use case
Design	"How could A be improved?"	Normative, avoid as main RQ
Evaluation	"How successful was implementation of A?"	Needs clear benchmark

Push toward explanation or testing. Exploration and description alone are usually not ambitious enough.

RQ framings to avoid

Avoid	Why
"What factors influence. . . ?"	Introduces unnamed concepts
"What explains. . . ?"	Introduces unnamed concepts
"How can. . . ?"	Leads to prescriptions, not empirical results
"How should. . . ?"	Normative rather than empirical
"To what extent. . . ?"	Purely descriptive; usually not ambitious enough

Better

openings:

- "What is the influence of X on Y in context Z?"
- "Why does X vary across. . . ?"
- "Under what conditions does A lead to B?"

The Role of Theory

- A **conceptual framework** is the lens through which you study your topic
- It helps you: define key concepts, derive expectations or hypotheses, connect findings to broader debates
- Even qualitative, inductive research needs theoretical grounding
- **Minimum 5 peer-reviewed international articles** in C2

Example: studying platform labour, you could draw on algorithmic management (Wood et al., 2019) or platform capitalism (Srnicek, 2017).

Data Collection: Minimum Requirements

- **Interviews**: minimum **10 respondents** (can vary by design)
- **Surveys**: minimum **80 complete responses**
- **Document analysis**: minimum **400 pages**, valid sample
- **Social media**: minimum **300–500 posts** (manual) or more for computational
- **Existing datasets**: permitted and often the best choice

Ethics and privacy

- **Privacy checklist** due before session 3 (signed by me)
- **Informed consent** required if you collect primary data from humans

Important

Data collection must begin by Week 5. Start identifying data sources this week.

Part 5

Our theme and your ideas

Our Theme: Key Debates

Digital Governance

- Digital transformation of the public sector (Dunleavy et al., 2006; Mergel et al., 2019)
- AI in government (Margetts & Dorobantu, 2019); EU DSA and DMA

Platform Labour and the Gig Economy

- Algorithmic management (Wood et al., 2019; Rosenblat, 2018)
- Worker classification (De Stefano, 2016); platform capitalism (Srnicek, 2017; Vallas & Schor, 2020)

Power in the Digital Economy

- Surveillance capitalism (Zuboff, 2019); algorithmic bias (Pasquale, 2015; O'Neil, 2016)
- Digital repression (Roberts, 2018); the platform society (van Dijck et al., 2018)

Discussion

Brainstorm round: we go student by student.

1. What is your **topic** and why does it interest you?
2. What is your **X, Y, and Z** as you currently see them?
3. What **data** do you plan to use, and is it accessible?
4. What are your **biggest uncertainties** right now?

Everyone else: one constructive question or suggestion per presenter.

For Next Week (Meeting 2, April 30)

Submit by Tuesday 28 April at 10:59 via Canvas

- Draft of **Chapter 1**: problem, objective, RQ (with named X, Y, Z), sub-questions, relevance
- Draft of **Chapter 2**: key concepts, theoretical framework, at least 5 peer-reviewed articles

Peer feedback

- You will be in a group of 4 with an assigned feedback partner
- Read your partner's C1 and C2, bring written constructive comments to the Thursday meeting

Groups of 4 and pairings will be shared on Canvas by Monday 27 April.

Key References

Research methods:

- Bryman, A. (2016). *Social Research Methods*. 5th ed. OUP.
- Babbie, E. (2013). *The Practice of Social Research*. 13th ed. Cengage.
- Van Thiel, S. (2021). *Research Methods for Public Management and Administration*. Taylor & Francis.

On our theme:

- Srnicek, N. (2017). *Platform Capitalism*. Polity.
- van Dijck, J., Poell, T., & de Waal, M. (2018). *The Platform Society*. OUP.
- Zuboff, S. (2019). *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*. PublicAffairs.
- Vallas, S. & Schor, J.B. (2020). What do platforms do? *Annual Review of Sociology*, 46, 273–294.

Questions?

Dr. Shreyas Meher

meher@essb.eur.nl